GEC1044 Final Essay

Chinese Medicine : Theory and Practice (National University of Singapore)



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GEC1044 Chinese Medicine: Theory and Practice

Individual Assignment

Tutorial Class TD1

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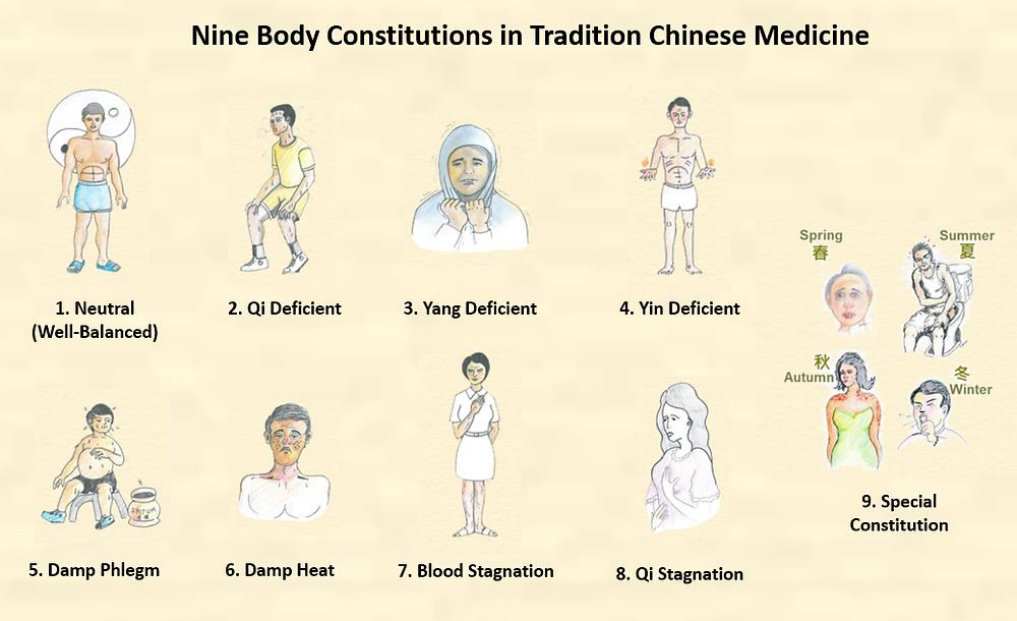
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1. Introduction

In the report, I aim to delve into a reflective analysis of my physical health status, addressing health-related issues that have come to my attention during the course. My exploration will focus on the nine principles of the Chinese body constitutions[1](Refer to Picture 1). Within the realm of Traditional Chinese Medicine (TCM), I realized the relationship between different body constitutions and various herbal remedies. To target the health problems identified in my personal assessment, I craft a special herbal recipe strategically incorporating ingredients with diverse characteristics according to my body constitution.



Picture 1. Nine Body Constitutions in TCM

2. Issues regarding with the Patient

2.1 Patient Profile

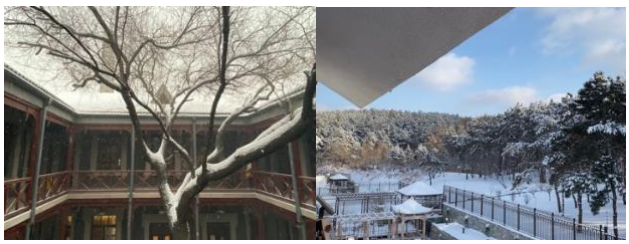
I am Bi Hexin, a 21-year-old National University of Singapore (NUS) student. Being an international student, I reside on campus for the entire semester. In addition to managing a demanding academic workload with numerous assignments, I am involved in various commitments, such as organizing and participating in co-curricular activities and internships. The busy schedule has resulted in **significant stress and emotional exhaustion**. Consequently, I often find myself sleeping late and maintaining poor eating habits, including consuming oily foods and irregular meal timings due to irregular and uncertain personal time. These lifestyle choices have affected my physical health to a large extent, leading to a **persistent feeling of bodily heaviness**.

Moreover, adapting to Singapore's hot and humid climate from China's cold and dry Northeast regions has been challenging(Refer to Picture 2.1). I often seek relief through cold beverages and prefer air-conditioned environments. I **feel intense pain during the menstrual period** as

[1] "Nine Body Constitutions in Chinese Medicine."

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well. Moreover, I still feel the thirst and the sensation of heat in various regions, such as the chest, palms, and soles of feet, and sometimes sore throat, though I drink a lot of water.



Picture 2.1. Photos of my hometown in China

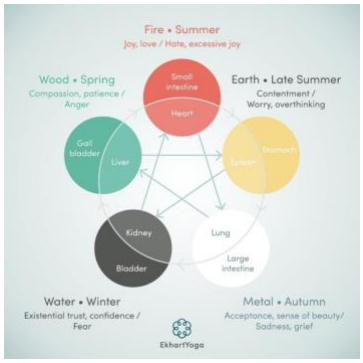
From my symptoms, I can ensure that I have the body constitution of Yin-Deficiency and Dampness-Heat illnesses due to my body's nature and life habits. The problem of Menstrual Cramps also troubles me a lot.

2.2 Patient's Diagnosis

(1) Yin-Deficiency

As I conclude from the symptoms, yin deficiency is my predominant body constitution. In TCM, the analysis of the body employs the concept of Yin and Yang, representing opposing forces[2]. It is vital to maintain harmony between Yin and Yang[3].

Some symptoms of Yin-Deficiency include consistent thirst, sweating, discomfort to the hot and humid environment, and lower immunity[4]. The insufficiency of Yin in the liver results in stagnation of Qi and heat in the liver, leading to bad emotions and affecting the metabolism, especially for females during menstruation. Drawing on the Five Phases Theory, where Earth generates Metal and subsequently Water within the body, the spleen corresponds to Earth, the lungs to Metal. Spleen Yin Deficiency impacts the stomach, resulting in stomach pains and emotional fluctuation[5] (Refer to Picture 2.2.1).



Picture 2.2.1 Five Elements in TCM

[2] "TCM Yin and Yang: The Key to Achieving Balance and Harmony."
[3] Kim and Kim, "Protocol for the Evaluation and Validation of Qi Blood Yin Yang Deficiency Pattern Questionnaire: Prospective Observational Study."
[4] Marshall, "Traditional Chinese Medicine and Clinical Pharmacology."
[5] Toner, "The Five Elements in TCM and Yin Yoga: Fire."

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(2) Dampness-Heat

I have identified Dampness-Heat as my secondary body constitution based on the symptoms outlined in the section above. When considering the interplay between dampness and heat, the priority lies in addressing excess dampness rather than eliminating heat from the body. Dampness, classified as a Yin pathogen, has a detrimental impact on Yang and tends to induce Qi stagnation[6]. Dampness is further categorized into internal and external types, with internal dampness attributed to dietary factors, such as excessive consumption of oily foods, and external dampness linked to environmental conditions like humidity or damp surroundings.

In my case, I believe I exhibit external dampness. External dampness typically manifests as a sensation of bodily heaviness, accompanied by symptoms like dizziness and joint soreness[7]. Among the organs affected by Dampness-Heat, the lungs, and large intestine are particularly relevant to my symptoms. Damp Heat in the large intestine results in the tongue displaying a thick yellow coat with consistent thirst[8].

(3) Menstrual cramps

Furthermore, this aspect holds minimal significance for women, particularly considering the notable influence of certain lifestyle factors. The frequent consumption of substantial quantities of cold water, icy beverages, and chilled foods, coupled with continuous exposure to air conditioning, creates an environment where external heat is experienced[9]. Paradoxically, despite this external perception of warmth, the internal nature of my body tends to be characterized by coldness. This dichotomy in temperature dynamics is a common occurrence among females, leading to the manifestation of symptoms such as menstrual cramps or, colloquially put, period pain.

3. Herbal Recipe

Following extensive research and consultations with TCM practitioners, I have opted for an enhanced rendition of the Bazhen Soup[10] as my final recipe (Refer to Picture 3). Below is detailed information regarding this unique recipe —"Thirteen Zhen Herbal Soup" （13 珍汤）



Picture 3. Traditional Bazhen Soup

[6] Ai et al., "Prevention and Treatment of 'Epidemic Toxin, Pathogenic Dampness, and Lung Deficiency' after COVID-19 Recovery Based on the Theory of 'Preventive Treatment of Diseases' in Traditional Chinese Medicine."
[7] Dashtdar et al., "The Concept of Wind in Traditional Chinese Medicine."
[8] Dashtdar et al., "The Concept of Wind in Traditional Chinese Medicine."
[9] "冷饮，到底有多伤身？！ ."
[10] "八珍汤：好药，却常被误用-北京药学会."

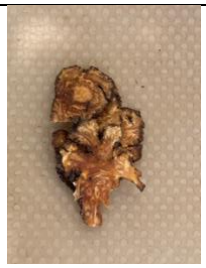
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3.1 Ingredients and Characteristics[11]

No.	Ingredient	Colour	Flavour	Quality
1	 党参 Tangshen(Codonopsis)	Light yellow	Sweet in taste	It falls under the category of Tonic herbs for Qi Deficiency and is applied to replenish one's 'Four Treasures' (Qi, Blood, Yin, Yang).
2	 桂圆 Longan	Originally translucent but turns sugary brown for longan dry	Sweet in taste	Circulates Qi, circulates blood.
3	 地龙 Earthworm	Skin in yellow and inside black	Salty and a little bit fishy	It pacifies internal Liver-Wind and stop tremors
4	 白术	White	Bitter but with a little bit sweet	Fortifies the spleen, enhance Qi, dries the humid and dampness

[11] "常用药材_中药网." (All ingredients characteristics are from this website)

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No.	Ingredient	Colour	Flavour	Quality
	White Atractylodes Rhizome			
5	 土炒白术 White Atractylodes Rhizome (soil baked)	Brown	Bitter in taste	It is for spleen deficiency
6	 川穹 Rhizoma Chuanxiong	Yellowish Brown	Bitter and pungent taste	Increase blood circulation and move Qi, expel wind, and release pain.
7	 熟地黄 Rahmanian Root	Black	Sweet	Nourishes the Blood Nourishes Liver Strongly enhance Yin and relieves wasting and thirsting disorder

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No.	Ingredient	Colour	Flavour	Quality
8	 黄芪 Astragalus Root	Light yellow	Sweet	Enhance Qi. It contains powerful antioxidants. It helps to improve immune system.
9	 枸杞 Goji Berry	Red	Sweet	Improves the performance of the liver and kidney. Enhances Qi and blood circulation.
10	 茯苓 Poria	White Cubes	Sweet and tasteless	Promotes urination, releases dampness, fortifies the spleen and stomach, calms emotion.
11	 甘草 Licorice	Brown colour like tree skin	Sweet	It is for conditions such as digestive problems, coughing and sore throat and resolve the problem of consistent thirst

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No.	Ingredient	Colour	Flavour	Quality
12	 乌鸡 Black Chicken	Black but meat in original chicken color	Regular meat taste	It is warm and supplementary in nature. It tonifies Qi and benefits digestion
13	 老姜 Ginger	Yellow	Spicy	Help the spleen and digestive systems to enhance Qi and Yang

3.2 Benefits of the Herbal Recipe

This soup encompasses a comprehensive array of 13 key elements, notably including the foundational components of Bazhen Soup: Rhizoma Ligustici Chuanxiong (川芎), Radix Glycyrrhizae Praeparata (甘草), Radix Rehmanniae Preparata (熟地黄), Radix Codonopsis (党参), Radix Angelicae Sinensis (当归), Poria (茯苓), Black Dates (黑枣), Rhizoma Atractylodis Macrocephalae (白术)[12]. The Ba Zhen recipes, have long been recognized as tonics with the traditional purpose of regulating irregular menstrual cycles. Additionally, this formula addresses the internal cold and external heat, effectively nourishing Yin, replenishing blood and Qi, elevating metabolic functions, and enhancing overall immunity. By alleviating stagnation in Qi and blood, it naturally resolves issues related to menstrual pain[13].

In addition to incorporating Ba Zhen elements, I have made a modification by substituting a small amount of Goji berries and Longan for the black dates. While Longan is intrinsically heaty in nature, it serves as an excellent material for nourishing Qi and blood[14]. By opting for these two ingredients with stronger medicinal properties, I have replaced black dates. Importantly, the usage of a minimal quantity ensures that it doesn't exacerbate the existing Yin deficiency and excessive internal heat in my constitution. Furthermore, this substitution not only avoids increasing internal heat but also contributes to enhancing overall immune function.

[12] "Traditional Ba Zhen Soup (传统八珍汤)."
[13] "Traditional Ba Zhen Soup (传统八珍汤)."
[14] "常用药材_中药网."

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To enhance the effectiveness of White Atractylodes Rhizome (白术), I have introduced soil-baked Bai Zhu (土炒白术) into the mixture. Soil baking is a method specifically employed to reinforce the spleen-nourishing properties[15]. Given that Bai Zhu inherently strengthens the spleen, invigorates Qi, and dispels dampness, the addition of soil-baked Bai Zhu intensifies its potency. Doubling the quantity serves to amplify the beneficial effects of Bai Zhu.

I incorporated the earthworm (地龙) into the recipe. This ancient remedy finds its roots in the earliest Chinese pharmacological masterpiece, the "Shennong Ben Cao Jing," where 67 types of animal-based medicines, including earthworms, were documented. Classified as a lower-grade herb in the "Shennong Ben Cao Jing," earthworms are recognized for their efficacy in clearing heat, calming agitation, promoting blood circulation, addressing asthma, and facilitating diuresis[16]. Earthworms possess a cooling nature and are associated with the liver meridian, displaying robust heat-clearing properties. This aligns perfectly with my usual tendencies towards excess heat and symptoms of damp heat.

I use two essential regular foods—black chicken and ginger to cook the soup. With its neutral nature and sweet taste, black chicken is for nourishing the body and replenishing energy. Renowned for its ability to nourish Yin, enrich the blood, clear heat, tonify the liver and kidneys, strengthen the spleen, and alleviate diarrhea, black chicken serves as an excellent ingredient[17]. Adding ginger complements this by harmonizing the spleen and stomach, promoting vital energy and blood production[18]. Black chicken soup offers the dual benefit of replenishing Qi and blood, promoting blood circulation, invigorating the spleen, dispelling dampness, and enhancing the body's immune system.

This wholesome combination ensures a robust vitality of Qi and blood, fortifying the spleen and kidneys against invading external pathogenic factors such as wind, cold, and dampness.

3.3 Cooking Process

Step 1: Purchase all the ingredients needed from the local TCM clinic and supermarket.



[15] "土炒白术_土炒白术的性味归经、功效及主治、化学成分、炮制方法及作用、药理作用_医学百科."
[16] "百度百科-验证."地龙（中药材）
[17] "乌鸡的做法，乌鸡的功效与作用_椰子_泰和县_滋补."
[18] Wu and Liang, "Food Therapy and Medical Diet Therapy of Traditional Chinese Medicine."

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Step 2: Prepare the ingredients into suitable quantities that are ready to put in the rice cooker.



Ingredient	Quantity
党参 Tangshen(Codonopsis)	10g
桂圆 Longan	5g
地龙 Earthworm	10g
白术 White Atractylodes Rhizome	10g
土炒白术 White Atractylodes Rhizome (soil baked)	10g
川穹 Rhizoma Chuanxiong	10g

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Ingredient	Quantity
熟地黄 Rahmanian Root	10g
黄芪 Astragalus Root	10g
枸杞 Goji Berry	5g
茯苓 Poria	10g
甘草 Licorice	3 slices (8g)
乌鸡 Black Chicken	2 whole chicken wings
老姜 Ginger	4 slices

Step 3: Add 1.5 liters of water into the rice cooker and set the time to 1 hour and 30 minutes.

*Rice cooker usually with higher pressure in the pot, shortening the time for cooking.





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Step 4: Add some salt; the soup is ready to enjoy!



4. Evaluation

4.1 Taste of the herbal soup

To begin with, this soup boasts exceptional flavours, thanks to the addition of black chicken, which imparts a rich and savoury taste. The inclusion of ginger effectively eliminates any residual gaminess from the meat, leaving behind a broth that is purely delicious. Moreover, there is no need to worry about an overpowering medicinal taste; quite the contrary, the herbs incorporated into the soup enhance its overall flavour profile. For instance, the earthworm is salty, it complements the predominantly sweet taste of the other medicinal ingredients such as Goji and Longan.

4.2 Feeling after drinking the herbal soup

I prepared and consumed this soup after my menstrual cycle, when there typically tends to be a deficiency in both qi and blood, resulting in a pale complexion. However, this time, there was a noticeable improvement in my overall condition. My body quickly returned to a more balanced state, and remarkably, I felt a significant difference. In fact, with leftover ingredients, I made the soup again, and this time, I sensed a considerable reduction in damp heat within my body. The persistent thirst I used to experience diminished, thanks to the helpful properties of licorice. Simultaneously, as my qi and blood became more balanced, my mood improved significantly, making me feel more energetic and revitalized.

4.3 Enhancement

It is worth noting that those with extreme and severe Qi or Yang deficiency may consider reducing the amount of poria, while individuals dealing with sever dampness heat should exercise caution with dried longan or opt for a lesser portion, given its heat-inducing properties[19].

[19] "红枣、桂圆、枸杞子……'中药零食'想吃就能吃？错！_食用."

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5. Conclusion

In conclusion, this herbal soup recipe emerges as an ideal solution for students, boasting both simplicity in preparation and with a good taste. Its targeted approach addresses common stress-related issues and delicate balance of Yin Yang. With a specific focus on vital organs like the kidney, spleen, and lung and heart, this soup actively promotes improved blood. All in all, I think this recipe address most problems of university students. Try it!

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